▶ JAMMU AND KASHMIR

The Toll of Negligence

The Nowgam police station blast leaves plenty of questions unanswered

By **Kaleem Geelani**

IT WAS ON AN OLD MIGRANT PROPERTY, in a densely populated residential area and surrounded by houses, that the Nowgam police station stood. Strange place to store 358 kg of ammonium nitrate, chemicals and batteries. The same explosive used in the November 10 Red Fort blast in Delhi.

What was the stuff doing back in Nowgam, uptown of Srinagar, ground zero of the crackdown that exposed the 'white collar terror' network? The recovered explosives are the 'case property' of Nowgam Police, which had registered a case under various sections of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) and Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, an investigation under which led to the busting of the Faridabad module and the recovery of 2,900 kg of bomb-making material from Faridabad. Procedure dictates that all evidence be submitted before a magistrate in the original locale of the case. So, part of it was put in containers and carted in trucks over 1,000 km to Nowgam.

SAMPLE TURNS LETHAL

It was 11:20 pm on November 14 when the folly of the move came through. Loud and clear—even 30 km away. The neighbours were preparing to sleep when the blast, accompanied by a flash of blazing light, threw them out of bed. The station, separated from the main road only by an empty compound, turned to cinders. Body parts were found half a mile away.

At the time of the accident, samples of the explosives were being packed in small bags to be taken for analysis to the Forensic Science Laboratory in Jammu. Collection of forensic evidence is mandatory under the Bharatiya Nagrik Suraksha Sanhita. Among the nine killed were MBA-turned-cop Asrar Ahmad, set to take over the Nowgam case for the Special Investigation Agency; a posse of police forensic hands, lab assistants; and a tailor called in to stitch pouches.

Director General of Police Nalin Prabhat ruled out any terror angle—scotching the claim by Jaish-e-Mohammed proxy Peoples Anti-Fascist Front, owning up to the attack. Questions are naturally being asked. Why cart the entire cache to Nowgam when a sample may have sufficed? Why choose this facility, nestled amidst a residential area, to store it? An investigation under the chairmanship of the principal secretary of the home department and comprising the IG Kashmir zone, Srinagar district magistrate and a senior scientist from the Central Forensic Sciences Laboratory will try to answer them.

A central official says police appear to have been a touch casual—perhaps because the material was not RDX. "They could have sought an exemption on submitting the evidence, given its quantity, or handed it over to the NSG, army or paramilitary, all of whom are far better equipped for this," he says.

The crackdown itself is proceeding at a rattling pace. Pre-dawn raids on November 18 claimed to have found a 'Jaish linkage' with the banned Dukhtaran-e-Millat. Dozens have been detained. Bilal Ahmad Wani, a Qazigund local, committed self-immolation after his son was picked up. A much smaller blaze than the one at Nowgam, but also a lesson in the handling of explosive material. ■

—with Pradip R. Sagar



WRONG KIND OF AMMO The police station at Nowgam in flames, Nov. 14

Takeaways

- **Ammonium nitrate seized in Faridabad 'white collar terror' case explodes in Nowgam**
- **The 358-kg explosive cache was carted over 1,000 km by road to be shown as evidence**